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ARTICLE

Carnivore salarymen and herbivore males: *Kimi no Na wa* and the shift to the omnivorous person

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ABSTRACT

Concerns of gender equality and fluidity has been a long-standing issue in contemporary society for decades, however, recently, the pressing issue surrounding media representations of gender has come to the forefront. The rise of feminist studies over the last few decades has led to a cornucopia of research on manga and anime in relation to femininity, but fewer examine masculinity or gender fluidity. This paper will expand the study of both femininity and masculinity but will mainly focus on masculinity, in the form of the Carnivore Woman and the Herbivore Man, with an argument towards the "Omnivorous Person." The omnivorous person can be thought of as an extension and paralleling to gender fluidity. As a highly accessible medium, through fantasy and metaphor, anime and manga have the ability to display a collective consciousness of Japanese society. To further elaborate on these new gender trends within Japanese popular media, a textual analysis of the anime film *Kimi no Na wa* (2016) will be used as exemplar. It is impossible to conduct any in-depth study that is truly representative of a genre, especially considering the magnitude and vastness of manga and anime, however, selecting a text that is "popular" can suppose some degree of cultural relevance.

KEYWORDS

carnivore girl, gender fluidity, herbivore man, masculinity, textual analysis

1 | INTRODUCTION

When talking or writing about Japanese society and its relationship to cultural products, gender matters. If any quantitative proof were needed, one could refer to the *Global Gender Gap Report 2018*, a report that captures the magnitude of gender-based disparities worldwide by measuring countries' gender gap in terms of economic participation, educational attainment, health, and political empowerment.[1] Out of 149 countries measured, Japan ranks 110 and has gradually moved down the list throughout the years, dropping nine positions since the 2012 report (7). Out of all G8 nations, Japan is ranked the worst, having an astonishing 38 countries between them and the next G8 nation, Italy. Though this scholar remains mainly a qualitative scholar, they do think that quantitative analysis provides a valuable view of gender, race, and class discrepancies. Statistically speaking, it would seem that living as a "woman" or a "man" in Japan still makes a significant difference. The question then becomes, what would Japanese society, and humanity in general, look like beyond the means of stringent binary gender? What are the possibilities of androgynous, or what this scholar would like to term as the "omnivorous" person? To picture such an ideal, this paper will explore such notions by examining how a Japanese animated film, *Kimi no Na wa*, may provide insight to the possibilities of the omnivorous person.

Within the past couple of decades, East Asian countries have witnessed a shift from hegemonic forms of masculinity. For example, Japan has witnessed the inception of the *bishōnen* (beautiful youth boy) and the herbivore male, while Korea has produced the *kkonminam* (flower boy).[2] These new forms of masculinity have seen a more androgynous identity, showcasing both masculine and feminine personas. Most importantly, in the development of such forms, though these

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individuals may seem more progressive in their gender characteristics, their sexuality is never questioned—These men are always assumed to be heterosexual.[3] A popular form in which this "softer" masculinity can be viewed in Japan is from manga and anime. Japanese manga and anime have been recognized increasingly in recent years as a valuable site for textual analysis and sociology. As a highly accessible medium, through fantasy and metaphor, anime and manga have the ability to display a collective consciousness of Japanese society. As manga scholar Frederik Schodt contends, "reading manga is like peering into the unvarnished reality of the Japanese mind" (31).

The rise of feminist studies over the last few decades has led to a cornucopia of research on manga and anime written by and aimed at girls (Napier 12). In contrast, the analysis of masculinity and "men's studies" has generally been limited to pornography, salaryman narratives, and science fiction successes such as *Akira* and *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (Napier 15). This paper will expand the study of both femininity and masculinity in the form of the Carnivore Salaryman and the Herbivore Male, with an argument to what the author proposes is a push towards the "Omnivorous Person." To further elaborate on these new gender trends within Japanese popular media, a textual analysis of the anime film Kimi no Na wa[4] will be used as exemplar. It is impossible to conduct any in-depth study that is truly representative of a genre, especially considering the magnitude and vastness of manga and anime; however, selecting a text that is "popular" can suppose some degree of cultural relevance. Before analyzing the film, a brief history of hegemonic masculinity within Japan will be discussed.

2 | HEGEMONIC MASCULINITY AND THE CARNIVOROUS SALARYMAN

While men clearly benefit from structural configurations that privilege men and hyper-masculinity over women and hyper-femininity, men's structural privilege within society does not preclude some masculinities from benefiting at the expense of others.[5] Hegemonic masculinity is a term given to the most culturally sanctioned and socially privileged form of masculinity. Often hegemonic masculinity acts as the standard by which society evaluates all other masculinities—it is the unmarked masculinity, the version from which all differences emanate. One major influencer that the culture industry has on an individual is the conception of gender. Gender is a socially constructed concept, consisting of expectations, characteristics, and behaviors that members of a society deem appropriate for men and women.[6] Gender is a routine performative act in people's everyday activities that it holds taken-for-granted assumptions, aligning with dominant ideals standardized as common sense, so that anyone who questions the status quo is viewed as a deviant from the norm.[7] In other words, the performance of gender identity through our gender expression represents the complacency within the normative system regulated but a small, yet powerful group of people. The decision to perform gender then becomes an oppressive and power-binding act placed on those who do not have power or control over socially constructed norms. The only way that particular gender roles stay relevant is by people giving into them, and not opposing them.

The construction of gender is based on socially constructed statuses. These statuses assign individuals with particular sets of attributes and roles, based on their biological sex. As explained by Spencer Cahill, during childhood, children are socialized to learn that only two identities exist, boy or girl—man or woman (167). Gender constancy is socialized in children through the policing of the way they walk, talk, and gesture. Children learn at a young age how to perform their gender, and by doing so, complacency with the hegemonic and heteronormative is formed. As Butler would argue, when gender is performed, people are not recognized as an individual, but a part of the system that has been constructed (18). As a social institution, gender creates distinguishable social statuses for individuals. As a system of stratification, gender constructs a hierarchy that ranks men above women of the same race and class. Thus, gender becomes a way that hegemony operates, by enforcing a superior male gender and an inferior female persona. Hegemonic masculinity is contextually specific but universally accepted. Jane Garde suggests that Western hegemonic masculinity encompasses four dominant norms featuring masculinity: power, opposition toward femininity, domination, and objectification of nature, and the avoidance of emotion (8).

In Western societies, two normative masculinity markers are strong rejection of femininity and homosexuality, thus "real" masculinity is measured by the level of opposition an individual has from femininity and homosexuality.[8] The phenomenon of heterosexual attraction is a development fostered out of gender-based schematics, in that people are taught that the two sexes are, and are supposed to be, different from each other.[9] Heteronormative standards for what are deemed normal situates men and women in a hierarchal relationship that portrays masculinity as active and powerful, while femininity is illustrated as being subordinate to male sexuality.[10] Heteronormativity creates opposing structures of femininity and masculinity that support men's greater power and status, and suggests that success for both men and women is contingent on whether or not they find a long-term romantic partner. This is more so enforced for women, as their success is not their education, financial stability, or other notable measures of success, but is strictly based on their

ability at obtaining a romantic relationship and their ability to emotionally support their male partner and raise children.

Industrialized societies treat an exclusively heterosexual orientation as essential, and violation of one's prescribed gender script would call into action the individual's adequacy as a man or woman.[9] Compulsory heterosexuality pressures women and men to engage in heterosexual activity, even if they prefer not to.[6] Yet, even the amount of sexual activity that a man or woman engages has to be balanced. This notion is especially truer to women. Women have the impossible task to come across as pure and virgin-like, but at the same time experienced, further binding them in the oppressive structure of the patriarchy. There is a need to have a close bond with their fellow brothers, but since homosexual practices are not a part of the traditional gender schema, they often times fulfill their need for a strong social bond by having intercourse with the same nonconsenting woman. Thus, to achieve social connection while at the same time avoiding criticism of deviancy, males become hypermasculine.

For contemporary postwar Japan, this figure of hegemonic hypermasculinity belongs to the carnivorous man (*nikushokukei danshi*), or the salaryman. The carnivorous man is a gender expression that has been the predominate ideal male standard for masculinity in Japan. They are proactive and assertive in both their professional and romantic endeavors. As Kumiko Endo describes, they are “reminiscent of the “corporate warrior” [also referred to as the salaryman] men of the yester year that led the Japanese economy to global prominence” (11). A salaryman (*sarariiman*) is a white-collar, male employee of a private sector organization, typically characterized by lifetime employment, seniority-based salaries and promotions, and a paternalistic concern for the employee on the part of the company in return for steady and diligent loyalty (120).[11] Values associated with *bushido*, or the traditions and morals of the samurai (i.e., duty, loyalty, self-sacrifice, and endurance), which were previously used to glorify the samurai and then later the Japanese soldier, are also ascribed to the salaryman (120).[11] Futoshi Taga provides examples of many commonplace militaristic expressions used in businesses, such as *kigyō senshi* (corporate warrior), *messhi hōkō* (selfless devotion), and *ichiba senryaku* (marketplace tactics/strategy) (131). With the end of the war, the salaryman became the new Japanese male—the embodiment of a modern, industrialized, and urban Japan.[11]

Yet few Japanese men perfectly fit the salaryman ideal. Moreover, the salaryman concept itself has never been static or stable. Rather, the salaryman is a construct that expands and fluctuates in response to national and world events, local practices, and social contexts. In the years since Japan's recession began in the 1990s, the salaryman concept has increasingly taken on negative undertones: excessive rigidity, competence only in the workplace, and impotence.[11] The salaryman and his privileged position are fraught with internal contradictions, as Connell and Messerschmidt suggest about all masculinities (840). The salaryman's control is always partial and never total. Nevertheless, the salaryman has retained this preferred position among Japanese masculinities because the salaryman has become integrated with the economic, social, and political structures of Japanese society.

As Anne Allison highlights in her book *Nightwork*, the salaryman lives a precarious existence (62). He is emasculated by his subservience to corporate Japan, yet during the heyday of Japan as an industrial conglomerate, he sought to reassert his masculinity after work in a ritualized activity. Before the collapse of Japan's economic bubble, many companies paid for their workers to attend hostess clubs on a regular basis. At these hostess clubs, women used conversation and limited physical contact to make salarymen feel desirable and powerful, the type of man who can purchase sex from women. Though sex rarely actually materialized. Rather than physical acts of intercourse, what companies bought was the illusion that hostesses desired sex from salarymen. The entire charade was designed to maintain worker productivity by building up the masculine ego (62).[12] Herein lies the fragility of the salaryman: He uses women as “objects” to prop up his unstable sense of self-worth, yet for this to work, the salaryman must mask his dependence on women, or face emasculation all over again (63).[12]

These three themes—money, power, and sex—define the salaryman, even as they constitute his weakness. The salaryman earns a decent wage, but he is by no means extraordinarily wealthy. His power is based on his privileged social position, yet this social position also renders the salaryman the servant of an impersonal economic system. Finally, the sexual and desirable self that is produced by the joint efforts of hostesses and salarymen would not exist without the economic transaction between hostess clubs and corporations, as well as the cooperation of hostesses who help maintain the illusion of male supremacy.

As Connell & Messerschmidt argue, “Hegemonic masculinities came into existence in specific circumstances and were open to historical change. More precisely, there could be a struggle for hegemony, and older forms of masculinity might be changed by new ones” (832–833). A good example of this is the case of Japan. When the early 1990s economic recession hit, also known as Japan's “Great Recession,” companies could no longer afford to pay for late nights at hostess clubs. As one might imagine, when this money evaporated, so too did one of the primary pillars supporting the salaryman's sense of masculine self-worth.

Entering into the 1990s and the new century, the salaryman remained a privileged member of Japanese society (23).[12] Nonetheless, he is a caricature of what he once was. The salaryman is now the butt of national jokes and a faded ideal that many young men now reject in favor of alternative lifestyles. One such alternative form of masculinity being the herbivore man.

3 | THE HERBIVORE MALE

Professor Morioka Masahiro explains that the herbivore man is a direct rejection of the *nikushokukei danshi* as he asserts, "as some men grow up, they realize that they are incapable of adapting to ideal images of masculinity and develop a deep inferiority complex which leaves them incapable of accepting their own bodies and desires, leading them to repress their sexuality and turn towards alternate means of manifestation" (13). Thus incepted the need for a different form of masculine gender expression. From 2008 to 2009, *sōshokukei danshi* (herbivore men) became a trendy, widely used term in Japanese. Coined by Fukasawa Maki, and meaning "grass-eating type men," it flourished in all sorts of media, including television, the Internet, newspapers and magazines, and could even occasionally be heard in everyday conversation. As it became more popular, its original meaning was diversified, and people began to use it with a variety of different nuances. In December 2009, it made the top ten list of nominees for the "Buzzword of the Year" contest sponsored by U-CAN.[13]

Fukasawa initially used the phrase to describe young men who are heterosexual but are not assertive in trying to pursue women, however, the discourse on *sōshokukei danshi* has varied over time (2).[13] While, at first, it only concerned young men's attitudes toward love, relationships, and sex, it quickly came to encompass entire lifestyles. Commentators discussed working life, appearance, values, and relationships. Chris Deacon, a men's studies researcher, has summarized the characteristics of *sōshokukei danshi* as being uncompetitively minded about jobs; being fashion conscious, enjoying shopping; being uninterested in dating, relationships, or sex; and being thrifty with money (123). In 2008, the Japanese magazine *DIME* interviewed Magumi Ushikubo, a marketing researcher, who provided a list of features that might label one as an herbivore man. Ushikubo's list consists of the following: (a) don't understand the appeal of sports; (b) when drinking out with friends, they often don't drink alcohol; (c) enjoyment in reading comics for young women; (d) even when staying at a woman's place they do not initiate anything sexual; (e) have an affinity for sweets; and (f) talks to their parents at least once a week (Nicolae 2013).

The aforementioned characteristics reference personality traits, whereas in 2009, reporter Yomiuri Shinbun offered physical attributes of a *sōshokukei danshi*, stating that they are slim, do not eat much, are enthusiastic about ecology, and are fashion conscious (Nicolae 2013).

Scholars Steven Chen and Justin Charlebois see Herbivore masculinity as a direct post-bubble-era rejection of traditional hegemonic salaryman masculinity. Chen, for example, sees herbivore men as "funky youth cultures" that emerged while "the salaryman's mode of life was questioned" (295). Charlebois argues that having a permanent career is suddenly shifting from being the only means of showcasing masculinity (94). As a result of a sociocultural generational change in the perspective of masculinity, the ideas of what it means to be masculine have also shifted. As a result, herbivore masculinity was created as an alternative gender practice. This change in context presumes a shift in societal priorities and cultural perspectives between generations.

Both Chen and Charlebois present the herbivore man as an emerging form of a "new man," as opposed to the outdated salaryman. One other very important part of herbivore masculinity, as argued by Chen and Charlebois, is a high focus on esthetics, and sporting effeminate looks, even using makeup. According to Chen, they "develop a feminized body that is distinguished from the salaryman. By adopting male beauty practices and gender-ambiguous fashion, they… transgress oppressive gender norms" (303). There then becomes a focus of not just a financial aspect of success and masculinity, but a focus on the man as a whole, both internally and externally. No longer is masculinity based on just an outward reflection of financial stability and provision to a family, but through the herbivore man, it is also an inward searching of the self.

Morioka enumerated the advantages and disadvantages of becoming romantically involved with herbivore men: (a) herbivore men place a low priority on sex and thus will not use a woman for her body; (b) they are interested in the human qualities of a woman such as how pleasant and interesting she is; and (c) when it comes to romantic relationships they desire stability (3–4). The disadvantages of dating a *sōshokukei danshi* are: (a) romantic relationships develop slowly; (b) the standards they use when choosing a female partner are difficult to understand; and (c) you cannot expect a dramatic, passionate, romance (3–4).[13] In response to these advantages and disadvantages, and incepted by the film of the same name, a complementary femininity was formed known as *nikushokukei joshi*, or carnivorous (meat eating) woman, a term denoting the display of aggressive behavior associated with Japanese females under 45. In this case, the *nikushokukei joshi* then becomes the

one who pushes and pursues a relationship with a man, with the goal of obtaining a serious boyfriend who could potentially be a husband (170).[14]

What could be potentially harmful is the dichotomizing of *nikushokukei* and *sōshokukei*, in which both gender expressions are portrayed to be in opposition to each other. Instead, thinking of the carnivore and herbivore types as a dialogical process that are in negotiation with each other could provide individuals with the freedom to explore their gender identity and ways in which to express that identity. This negotiation between *nikushokukei* and *sōshokukei* can be observed in both the male and female lead characters in *Kimi no Na wa*.

3.1 | Kimi no Na wa

Directed by Makoto Shinkai and produced by CoMix Wave Films, *Kimi no Na wa* (君の名は, *Your Name*) is an anime film that premiered on July 3, 2016, at the Anime Expo in Los Angeles, and later released in Japan on August 26, 2016. The film has garnered wide critical acclaim, having top awards at the 2016 Los Angeles Film Critics Association Awards, the 49th Sitges Film Festival, and the 71st Mainichi Film Awards (IMDd). It is currently under production with Paramount Pictures to be made into an American live-action remake (IMDb). Based on the novel that Shinkai wrote, which was released a month before the film, the story revolves around a young high school boy and a girl who mysteriously swap bodies on a regular basis for a period of about a couple of months. The boy, Taki Tachibana, lives in the urban sprawl of central Tokyo, where he attends school, goes to his part-time job at an Italian restaurant, and aspires to be an architect. In contrast, Mitsuha Miyamizu, lives in the countryside fictional town of Itomori in Gifu Prefecture's mountainous Hida region. Mitsuha is the daughter of the town mayor and comes from a family that is heavily tied to the traditions of the Miyamizu Shrine, which serves the town's local deity. Throughout the film, we see Mitsuha performing her duties to the shrine as a shrine maiden, making traditional sake, and going on pilgrimages to make offerings to the god of Miyamizu Shrine. In the background, there is news of a comet named Tiamat, which will be making its way across the sky of Japan within a few days. This comet eventually becomes a source of great beauty and great destruction for the village of Itomori, as a piece of the comet crashes into the small village, decimating both its surroundings and the populace of Itomori. To change the course of history and manipulate time, Taki and Mitsuha take advantage of their body-swapping experience to try to create another thread of history in which nobody in Itomori would die.

During the time that these two characters continue to body-swap, they become aware of the difficulties and nuances of each other's lives, encouraging a kind of understanding and empathy for one another that would likely be impossible if such an occult phenomenon had not happened. In being able to walk in each other's shoes, not only do they learn more about the other's personal life, but they are also able to empathize and learn about the others' gendered role in Japanese society. In doing so, their gender identities and ideals of what masculinity and femininity look like slowly moves from hypermasculine or hyperfeminine and to a more neutral or androgynous gender identity.

After being publicly embarrassed of performing a traditional shrine maiden technique of sake making by chewing rice in her mouth and spitting it back into a container for it to ferment, Mitsuha runs to the bottom of the shrine stairs and yells, “Please make me a handsome Tokyo boy in my next life!” [00:17:08]. Little did she know that her request would come to fruition, from that day on she randomly wakes up in Taki's body. This wanting to be someone else, someone from another gender particularly, speaks of the burdens that she faces in her ordinary life and in her female gender identity. She is burdened by responsibility and restriction, both in terms of being a shrine maiden living in a somewhat isolated urban town and, on a larger scale, being restrained to the defining scripts of femininity and being a woman. The admonishing of her strict father, the town mayor who doesn't live with the family but still corrects her behavior in public, only amplifies her sentiment. In a way, her father represents larger structures in society that restrict and police the gender identity of all. Her wanting to breakout of the confines of her rigid life and gender script is an outcry that many in society may have. Both men and women are stuck in a strict patriarchal gender binary and are looking for ways to subvert such standards.

There is something to be said about the fluidity the film portrays on varying levels, from temporality, spatiality, and gender—all of which are connected by the Shinto-like theological idea described by Mitsuha's grandmother as *musubi*:

> Grandma: Mitsuha, Yotsuha (Mitsuha's sister), do you know “Musubi”?
>
> Mitsuha: Musubi?
>
> Grandma: Musubi is the old way of calling the local guardian god. This word has profound meaning. Tying thread is Musubi. Connecting people is Musubi. The flow of time is Musubi. These are all the god's power. So, the braided cords that we make are the god's art and represent the flow of time itself. They converge and take shape. They twist, tangle, sometimes unravel,

> break, then connect again. Musubi - knotting. That's time. Drink. (Gives her granddaughters water)
>
> Mitsuha: Thank you.
>
> Yotsuha: I want some too!
>
> Grandma: That's also Musubi. Whether it be water, rice, or sake, when a person consumes something and it joins their soul, that's Musubi. [00:34:28–00:35:32]

Musubi affirms that everything is connected and affected by each other, and is a poetic declaration of sympoesis, or the idea that people cannot survive on their own.

The idea of *musubi* is physically realized by the red cord that connects Taki and Mitsuha. Though they are separated by 3 years, (not by age, but three actual years on a timeline), we find that they are connected by a red cord that Mitsuha made and gave to Taki on a subway. While Mitsuha knew who Taki was because she was traveling from the past to the future, Taki is unaware of who Mitsuha was. Mitsuha and her cord act as an umbilical cord to a historical past that Taki would otherwise have never been able to experience. Likewise, Mitsuha is able to also exist with the embodied knowledge of experiencing modernity through Taki's life, but she no longer sees his life from the fetishistic and essentializing perspective of just *wanting* to become "a handsome boy in Tokyo." When she swaps with Taki, she *is* a boy living in Tokyo. Through their experiences, they both learn to view each other in a deeply empathetic manner, despite the fact that they are diametrically opposed.

The cord also pays homage to, and is an intertextual rendering of, the folklore of the "red string of fate." Having multiple variants across East Asia, one adaptation tells of an old man who lives in the moon and comes out every night to search among kindred spirits to reunite them on earth, who have something to learn from each other, and when he finds them, he ties a red thread to them so they find their paths. Everyone has a red cord. We are on one end; on the other end is our destined soulmate. Two people are connected by this thread regardless of time, place, or circumstance. The red string might get tangled, contracted, or stretched, as life has its complexities, but the cord can never be broken. It is in essence, *musubi*, Taki's and Mitsuha's lives, like the cord, "twist, tangle, sometimes unravel, break, then connect again" [00:56:26].

Through their connection to each other, the idea of gender fluidity can be observed, where each starts to adopt both feminine and masculine traits that prove to be beneficial to their personality and sociability. For example, while swapped as Taki, Mitsuha uses her sewing skills, an otherwise "womanly" talent, to stitch together a hole in Taki's colleague, Ms. Okudera's skirt:

> Fellow restaurant staff 1(female): Oh, Ms. Okudera, your skirt!
>
> You OK?
>
> Fellow restaurant staff 2 (male): What happened?
>
> Fellow restaurant staff 1: Slashed.
>
> Ms. Okudera: That dick from earlier?
>
> Fellow restaurant staff 1: What now? Do you remember his face?
>
> Fellow restaurant staff 2: No.
>
> Taki: Come with me. (Takes Ms. Okudera to an office in the back of the restaurant)
>
> Fellow restaurant staff 2: Hey, Taki!
>
> Taki: Take off your skirt. Oh! I'll look the other way!
>
> (Cuts to scene where Taki is fixing the hole in Ms. Okudera's skirt)
>
> Taki: This won't take long. Done!
>
> Ms. Okudera: Wow, Taki! It looks better than before!
>
> Taki: Thank you for saving me today.
>
> Ms. Okudera: Actually, I was concerned about you. You're weak but quick-tempered. I like you better today. Never knew you had a *feminine side*. [00:25:06–00:25:47]

Through Mitsuha, and her sewing skills, Taki is able to gain the respect and admiration of Ms. Okudera, a person who he has a crush on. We see that the addition of feminine traits to his gender identity helps him with his relationship with someone from the opposite sex. This is emphasized in the next scene where, still in Taki's body, Mitsuha writes in his dairy about the events that occurred that day, ending her entry with: "Walked to the station with Ms. Okudera after work, thanks to my *feminine powers*!" [00:27:23]—acknowledging the strengths of being androgynous or gender fluid.

The anime alludes to the attractiveness of having a gender-fluid identity. In a scene the day after Taki and Mitsuha have switched bodies and are back to their normal selves, Taki's best friend, Tsukasa Fujii, who is a male, mentions how Taki was "kind of cute" the other day [00:27:47]. This can also be seen in Mitsuha's life. While in Mitsuha's body, Taki does a lot of athletic and physical activities, like playing sports, things deemed "manly." Those observing this, both male and female, find it quite attractive, as in one journal entry, Mitsuha asks, "Taki, why is a girl in love with me?" and Taki responding, "You're more popular when I'm you," [00:32:33] as we are shown scenes where a girl and a boy separately confess their love to Mitsuha.

Both Taki and Mitsuha benefit from adopting more gender-fluid identities. Through living the other's life and understanding what it is like to be both female and male, they are able to pick and choose the gender identity that they see fit and beneficial. Eventually, because they are cosmically connected and destined for each other, they become each other's soulmates, an altruistic statement in the film stating that they fully understand and empathize with each other. It is also a grand testimony to the positive outcomes of queering, or blurring, the gender binary, heteronormativity, and patriarchy. By dismantling these stringent structures, they find peace and happiness in accepting themselves and each other for who each other wants to be. They don't see a "boy" or a "girl", but instead strive to know the other more deeply and profoundly, as the title *Kimi no Na wa* (*Your Name)* suggests, they are not confined to a gender binary, but look at each other's name—as complex individuals intertwined, tangled, and tethered to each other.

4 | THE GENDER FLUID, OMNIVOROUS PERSON

Within the past couple of decades, a shift in masculine identity and performance has begun to occur in young males, and to discuss this phenomenon more easily the media have latched on to the term *sōshokukei danshi* as its signifier. Thus, to a certain extent, the very idea of *sōshokukei danshi* is a fabrication. It is not to say that the attributes given to *sōshokukei danshi* are not real. Rather, the particular categorizing of males as "herbivore" or "carnivore" is artificial. One who is labeled as herbivore does not necessarily embody every feature attributed to this grouping, but instead, the situation is far more fluid, as would be expected in the complex matter of identity.

Using Peterson's[15] notion of the cultural omnivore, instead of labeling an individual as a "carnivorous male," "herbivore male," or "carnivorous female," there is growing support for a more androgynous, free-deciding gender identity that will be called the "omnivorous person". Originally observing the consumption practices of higher-class individuals, Peterson noticed that these folks were adding diverse practices and cultural forms to their cultural repertoire—they were omnivores because they were developing a taste for everything and anything that pleased them (251). As Sullivan and Katz-Gerro contend, "the omnivore thesis also differs from accounts of cultural consumption as an aspect of lifestyles that is fluid, flexible, and transient, in the sense that consumption patterns are individualized" (196). This sort of idea of cultural fluidity can parallel with recent trends in gender-fluidity and androgynous identities that perform outside of the strict heteronormative gender binary. Regarding cultural omnivorousness, Gans argues that:

Omnivores have blossomed because more people have the time, money, and education to choose more culture from several taste levels, making all forms and genres of culture potential hunting grounds for them… In addition, a major sector of the omnivorous audience is young people, who not only have more time and disposable income but also freedom to choose variety of cultures than almost anyone else. They are still exploring tastes so as to identify their own, and the formation of "cultural identity" may begin with a period of omnivorousness. (31)

The idea of an ambiguous and personalized consumption identity can also transfer to others' developed identities, and modern industrialized countries have definitely seen progress in terms of gender, class, and race identities. By labeling the self as an omnivore on all levels means to queer our understandings of hegemonic standards of the ideological state apparatus.

The omnivorous person can be thought of as an extension and paralleling to gender fluidity. As a concept, fluidity is variously construed as changing, unstable, inconsistent, and ambiguous (32).[16] For example, some theorists have highlighted the fluidity of gender and sexuality in opposing notions of bodies, behaviors, and identities as fixed, stable, coherent, or clearly definable (33).[16] While illustrating the temporal and situational nature of gender performances, these arguments do not necessarily renounce the social construction and regulation of identity claims. As Judith Butler argues, "Gender performances cannot be theorized apart from the forcible and reiterative practice of regulatory sexual regimes" (15). Fluidity has also been conceptualized, however, as unbounded or unconstrained. In this framing, transgender fluidity is perceived as indicative of gender freedom and the primacy of individual choice and as destabilizing categories and boundaries. Bornstein asserts that "gender fluidity recognizes no borders or rules of gender" (52). Fluidity, thus, implies an escape from the constraints of gender assumptions and a refusal to stay within one category or another.

Fluidity is also about the rejection of normative identity. As part of a "strategy of identity destabilization," postmodern queer theories have questioned the "unity, stability, viability, and political utility of sexual identities (393)."[17] This questioning, which envisions identities as potentially malleable and fluid, ties into more nuanced concerns over the regulatory power of identification. More simplistically, however, identity has also been posited as something oppressive that individuals need to "move beyond." Commenting on discourses that mirror some of my own values, Judith Halberstam explains that "postmodern gender theory has largely been (wrongly) interpreted as a description of and a call for greater degrees of flexibility and fluidity" (3). Many young gays and lesbians think of themselves as a part of a "post-gender" world, and for them, the act of "labeling" becomes a sign of oppression they have happily cast off to move into a pluralistic world of infinite diversity (42).[18] This rejection of fixed identity relies on the potential of fluid, in this case, unbounded, performances and affiliations of gender. Further, the tendency to focus on the "creative agency of individuals" may underemphasize hegemonic power relations (29).[19]

Butler's notion of gender performativity, which grounds much theorizing on gender fluidity, is conceptualized as a site of active, agentic disruption (344). As Penelope Deutscher argues, "The notion that gender is troubled [that is, constituted as ambiguous or contradictory] is turned into the notion that one is troubling gender [that is, subverting it] (157). By allowing choice, as in the omnivorous person, there is a queering/subverting of the heteronormative gender binary, prioritizing individual choice of gender identity.

5 | CONCLUSION

For many years, the hegemonic masculine standard of the salaryman was seen as pertinent to the prosperity of Japan. However, as economic struggles hit worldwide in the 1990s, especially in East Asian countries, the stability of the salarymen also faltered (Matthews and White 2012). Thus, the birth of the herbivore male is born. This current subversion of hegemonic masculinity can be seen from the perspective of older generations as adding to the current problems such as Japan's economy, aging society, and low birthrate to name a few, it is also inexorably linked to the crisis in gender roles. The sōshokukei danshi are thought to be not particularly keen on finding a wife, let alone any romantic relationship, or just having sexual encounters—thus leading to their supposed blame for the low birthrate. They do not like to make expensive purchases, but rather concentrate on smaller, esthetic treatments—thus, poor consumption rates damaging the economy can partially be blamed on them. They do not want to dedicate their lives to a full-time career for a company, but instead pursue their dreams and ambitions which often involves part-time work—thus, Japan's stagnation can be blamed on them (141).[20] All of these accusations pinpoint the selfishness committed by the sōshokukei danshi, as they are not living for the nation, company, or family, but instead for themselves. This individualistic character is truly the antithesis of Japanese hegemonic masculinity and femininity.

Although some may see this new attitude as counter to Japanese culture and values, this is but one perspective. While for older generations, this may be a time of crisis, for the herbivore male, it is a time of opportunity. The hegemonic responsibilities to the development of the nation no longer applies. With this newer masculine identity, the door has been opened for these new men to concentrate on themselves. While some may see it as selfishness, these young men are enjoying the opportunity to perform in a way that they believe is true to themselves. This is truly a momentous occasion for subverting hegemonic gender identity and is a great step in a progressive and accepting direction, but why not go further? Yes, the herbivore male adds more fluidity to our conceptions of masculinity, but why label it as part of the heteronormative gender binary? Why have categories like the salary man, the herbivore male, the housewife, or the carnivorous woman? Thus, to truly embrace gender fluidity this paper argues that we strive for the omnivorous person. A person who may or may not identify with the gender binary but has a free choice on what characteristics they adopt to create their identity. This may be an overly optimistic approach towards gender equality, thinking about the current hostile political standings in the world, but hopeful optimism is necessary to reinvigorate those who have been marginalized and pushed to the shadows and outskirts of society. If *Kimi no Na wa* is any indication of the possibilities of understanding the other gender, or even breaking stereotypical gendered characteristics, at the crux of it all, it is a plea for a more gender-fluid society.

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